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Section Title(S): BIRTH AND CHILDHOOD • LUGURU CULTURE

The Luguru social system requires a connection with at least three separate clans. Not only does one have *lukolo* and *mtala*, one must also have a relationship called *ugongo* (Swahili: *utani*) with another clan. *Ugongo* is an institutionalized joking relationship between linked clans which are conceptualized as being the exact structural equivalents. A man frequently marries an *mgongo*, who should at the same time be a cross-cousin. If she is not an actual cross-cousin, she is a classificatory one. Ideally a man should marry a FZD, but MBD is also thought of as being an excellent match. Where prolonged intermarriage has occurred a person can be both FZD and MBD at the same time.

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I have shown elsewhere (Brain 1969) that marriage is ideally matrilocal, but after about 3–4 years, by which time a child should have been born and weaned, the 'delayed right of bride removal' occurs, and a man frequently takes his wife to the area of his maternal uncle. At the same time his mother may leave her husband and join her brother and son on clan land. If he marries a matrilateral cross-cousin, of course, no move is necessary after the initial one to the wife's home. Marriage tends to be stable for about twenty years, after which the rate of divorce rises rapidly as mothers leave to live with their sons and brothers.

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The traditional belief system of the Luguru centered around a cult of the ancestral spirits, *mitsimu* (Sing. *mtsimu*) (see Brain 1973 and forthcoming). Rites for the spirits, *tambiko*, can only be performed with the assistance of the joking partners from the linked clan, the *wagongo*, symbolically indicating the interdependence and complementarity of the two structurally equal and opposite groups. Not only do the *wagongo* play an essential role in the ancestral rites, their presence is also crucial when a death occurs. They wash and prepare the corpse, dig the grave and place the body in it, on the left side if a woman, the right if a man. They also carry out all the necessary household duties at this time. It is clear that their function is to preserve the ritual purity of the bereaved and prevent them from being polluted by contact with death, which I have suggested elsewhere (Brain forthcoming) is the symbolic equivalent of incest. The possibility of incest and its connection with witchcraft is a constant source of anxiety (cf. Beidelman 1966: 361).

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In spite of the acephalous nature of Luguru society it is far from egalitarian. Each sub-clan has a core matrilineage which provides the leaders, and which has some of the attributes of an aristocracy, e.g. the elders have special names and privileges in the form of greetings and order of drinking at feasts. Generational differences are sharp; elder brothers are superior to younger; all brothers are superior to sisters; clan members are superior to *wanawana*. Not surprisingly, therefore, three sub-clan leaders—Hegha, Mbago and Kingalu—are believed to have superior mystical powers to those of other leaders. This is particularly pertinent to control of the rain (see Brain 1971). Under Indirect Rule one of these—Kingalu—was selected as a chief but later deposed.

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BIRTH AND CHILDHOOD

On the birth of a boy a single trill ululation, *kigelegele*, is given to announce the fact; a girl child rates a double trill. The afterbirth and cord, *kitovu*, are buried, usually in the floor of the hut where the birth takes place. This customarily would be  179 the new mother's mother's hut. It is important to know where one's cord is buried (cf. Uchendu 1965: 58–9). The father's sister *sangazi*—female father—is also present, and plays an important role, as she does at all rituals involving her brother's daughter, thereby emphasizing the complementarity of the two descent groups. It is she who shaves the child's head after 40 days. This hair is buried in the same place. All small children may be termed *mwanadodo*—little child; there is also differentiation by sex: a

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boy is called *songoro*, a girl *kihinza*. When a child is born, black thread is put on its wrists, ankles and loins. When the child is about 30 days old, the father brings white beads which are strung in the same places. The ones around the loins stay for about three years for a boy; in the case of a girl they remain on for life. The significance of the colors involved will be considered later, but the Luguru say that they are '*kwa urembo tu*'—just for prettiness.

Ceremonial During Infancy And Childhood

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